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Social Movements, Political Parties, and Democratic Theory

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ABSTRACT: New left-libertarian social movements invoke an ancient communitarian democratic theory against the contemporary practice of competitive elite democracy. Two explanations for this phenomenon are explored. First, in a cyclical model, challenges to representative democracy are viewed as recurring expressions of dissatisfaction with representative institutions. Second, in a structural differentiation model, the practices of left-libertarian movements trigger a pluralization of political decision modes in advanced capitalist democracies, even if such participatory innovations fall short of the direct democratic ideal expressed by movement activists. Although the cyclical model has some merit, on the whole, the structural differentiation model provides an analytically more powerful explanation of recent social movement activity.

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IT is probably one of the very few valid generalizations in the literature on social protest and collective mobilization that social movements arise only when aggrieved groups cannot work through established channels to communicate new claims into the political process of authoritative decision making. The closure of existing avenues of participation, such as those provided by political parties or interest groups, is a necessary, though not a sufficient, condition for the emergence of unconventional, disruptive, and sometimes violent collective mobilization.[1]

In this vein, the so-called "new" social movements in advanced capitalist democracies in the 1970s and 1980s responded to a situation in which novel demands inspiring important constituencies at least initially did not strike a responsive chord in the existing vehicles of interest intermediation. Whereas political parties and established interest groups have been primarily organized around economic-distributive issues, that is, the allocation of scarce monetary resources to political constituencies, new social movements are predominantly concerned with the procurement of pure public goods characterized by both joint production and nonexcludability from consumption. Such goods are typically intangible in the sense that individuals cannot claim particular shares of the good in the same way that distributive collective goods can be pocketed by the recipients of pensions, higher wages, medical benefits, farm subsidies, and most of the other collective goods produced in the run-of-the-mill distributive political struggle.

New social movements appear in at least two forms. On the one hand, they engage in a politics of space. In the politics of space, citizens mobilize against the physical and natural consequences of how space is organized by a political economy that is primarily concerned with distributive issues. Environmental protection, land-use planning, urban zoning, transportation, industrial siting, minimizing waste disposal, and the like are typical issues involved in the politics of space. On the other hand, new movements practice a politics of social identity, in which participants work toward a redefinition and reconstitution of individual and collective identities as well as social relations that would go beyond the stereotypes generated by contemporary market relations, political institutions, and cultural conceptions. This politics of social identity is expressed particularly in the women's movements—abortion, anti-pornography, sexual harassment, marital abuse, and so on—and the movements of cultural and physical minorities, such as gays, ethnic minorities, and the handicapped.

Both currents of new movements oppose the commodification of society in a capitalist market economy, be it through the undervaluation of nature and space or the transformation of individual and collective identities by economic exchange relations. They are on the left in their opposi-

1. Of course, the intensity of deprivation, the resources of the mobilizing actors, the leaders' strategic skills, and the opponents' counterstrategies contribute to the extent of mobilization and the success or failure of such efforts.

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tion to markets as the dominant social governance structure. Moreover, both strands of these movements oppose the bureaucratization of society in economics and politics that allegedly suffocates the ability of individual citizens to participate in the definition of collective goods and identities. Instead, they call for a culturally libertarian transformation of social institutions that gives more leeway to individual choice and collective self-organization outside the economic commodity cycle or bureaucratic political organization. This political thrust is reinforced by the experience that it is precisely the highly bureaucratized political party machines and interest groups—business, labor, professions, churches, and so on—that have been unresponsive to the demands of the left and libertarian social movement sector.[2]

The stakes and the struggle of the left and libertarian social movements thus invoke an ancient element of democratic theory that calls for an organization of collective decision making referred to in varying ways as classical, populist, communitarian, strong, grass-roots, or direct democracy against a democratic practice in contemporary democracies labeled as realist, liberal, elite, republican, or representative democracy. I have no intention of presenting yet another abstract confrontation of the two alternative conceptions of democracy, together with some kind of synthetic blend that can overcome these polarities.[3] Nor do I intend to measure the distance between the direct democratic ideals and the practices of contemporary left-libertarian social movements. Instead, I wish to explain the reasons why contemporary social movements still invoke the image of direct democracy and the possible consequences this may have for democratic institutions. Two hypotheses about the relationship between established democratic procedures and the images and practices of contemporary social movements may be advanced. First, in a cyclical model, challenges to representative democracy are viewed as recurring expressions of dissatisfaction with representative institutions. Second, in a structural differentiation model, the practices of left and libertarian social movements are hypothesized to alter the democratic process in advanced capitalism and trigger a pluralization of political decision modes, even if the participa-

2. Frank L. Wilson points out that the strength of new social movements is not directly related to the incidence of corporatist interest intermediation. I would add that regimes with pronounced partocracy—Belgium, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands—also display strong movement mobilization. See Frank L. Wilson, "Neo-Corporatism and the Rise of New Social Movements, " in *Challenging the Political Order*, ed. Russell J. Dalton and Manfred Kuechler (New York: Oxford University Press, 1990), pp. 67-84.

3. For good reviews of these issues, see Benjamin Barber, *Strong Democracy* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984); Robert Dahl, *A Preface to Democratic Theory* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1956), chaps. 1-3; Robert A. Dahl, *Democracy and Its Critics* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1989), chaps. 1-2; David Held, *Models of Democracy* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1987); William H. Riker, *Liberalism against Populism* (Prospect Heights, IL: Waveland Press, 1982); Claus Offe and Ulrich K. Preuss, "Democratic Institutions and Moral Resources," in *Political Theory Today*, ed. David Held (Oxford: Polity Press, 1991), pp. 143-71.

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tory innovations fall short of the direct democratic ideal expressed by movement activists.

SOCIAL PROTEST AND CYCLES OF DEMOCRATIC DECISION MAKING

The idea that cycles play a role in democratic decision making was first introduced into contemporary debates by Kenneth Arrow.[4] If individuals have different preference rankings over a given set of alternatives and always vote on pairs of alternatives with simple majority as their collective decision rule, no unique collective preference may exist that best reflects the preference rankings of the participating individuals and wins in all runoffs between alternatives—the "Condorcet winner." Arrow then went on to prove that this paradox cannot be remedied unless at least one of several intuitively rational principles of democratic decision making—such as nondictatorship, Pareto optimality, unrestricted domain, and independence of preference rankings from irrelevant alternatives—are violated.

The response of political theorists and empirical political scientists to this formal result has varied. Some have claimed that the practical relevance of cycling majorities is quite limited and does not apply to the key political alternatives contested in contemporary democracies. Among those who accept the relevance of cycling, one group argues that cycling is actually good for stable democracy because it assures that losers in one round of the political game can be winners in a later round. Pluralist systems with cycling majorities thus can detach the popular legitimacy of specific decisions and rulers from the legitimacy of the political constitution.[5] Other theorists, however, argue that cycles endanger democracy because they undermine citizens' faith in the rationality of democratic decision rules and undercut the stability of constitutional governance. As a remedy, they recommend institutions, that is, enforced rules of the game that constrain the range of alternatives submitted and the probability of alternatives to be accepted in democratic decision making. Such institutions include all the mechanisms of political representation and agenda building advocated by realist democratic theories to overcome the shortcomings of direct democracy among which cycling majorities and indecisiveness rank high: a predominance of elected representatives over citizen participation, discriminating electoral systems to limit the fragmentation of preferences represented, and rules of decision making in parties and legislatures that centralize control over political agendas.[6]

4. Kenneth J. Arrow, *Social Choice and Individual Values* (New York: John Wiley, 1951). The central underlying idea of Arrow's paradox was, of course, provided by the Marquis de Condorcet over 150 years earlier.

5. Nicholas R. Miller, "Pluralism and Social Choice," *American Political Science Review*, 77(3):734-47 (1983).

6. See Riker, *Liberalism against Populism*; Joseph A. Schlesinger, *Political Parties and the Winning of Office* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1991); Kenneth J. Shepsle, "Studying Institutions: Some Lessons from the Rational Choice Approach," *Journal of Theoretical Politics*, 1(2):131-47 (1989).

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Advocates of institutions that are designed to overcome the instability of participatory democracy, however, are vulnerable to the counterargument that if citizens cannot agree on stable collective preference functions, they may also be unable to choose stable institutional rules. If the choice of institutional rules biases policy choices in favor of or against some alternative, rational actors will prefer the institutions that maximize their chances to win at the policy level. Thus institutions inherit disagreements about policies and cannot provide stability.[7] A cycle of decision alternatives may be superseded by a cycle of institutions and decision rules, unless stricter decision rules are imposed that make it impossible to change the institutions themselves. In this vein, provisions that constitutions can be altered only with qualified majorities—such as three-fifths or two-thirds—avert cycling but violate Arrow's nondictatorship postulate because they give a minority veto rights over rule changes.

The rigidity of institutions provides the bridge between cycles of democratic choice and social movements. If the established democratic institutions systematically underprivilege certain policy preferences and if the rules themselves are impossible to change even if a majority of citizens so desires, dissenters can only step outside the established framework of political governance and engage in protest. The role of institutions in democracy thus explains a mechanism by which social movements come about. Institutions may be necessary to overcome democratic instability, yet at the same time they constrain democratic principles.[8] This mechanism inducing citizens to switch from normal rule-guided participation to exceptional protest politics does not by itself yield a cycle of political practices that returns to its origin. We need a second mechanism that explains how citizens move back from exceptional to normal democratic politics. This mechanism has to do precisely with the disappointments of direct democratic practice. It has been explained in the works of Albert Hirschman and Sidney Tarrow.

Albert Hirschman's analysis of "shifting involvements"[9] postulates endogenous mechanisms that push citizens back and forth between a preference for private individual—market—choices, accompanied by a constrained sphere for collective decision making within representative democracy and a desire for public collective choices through deliberation and direct democratic participation. Each of the alternative decision modes brings about its own disappointments. These disappointments

7. This point has been made against Riker's liberal conception of democracy by Dahl, *Democracy and Its Critics*, p. 154, based on the work of Jules Coleman and John Ferejohn, "Democracy and Social Choice," *Ethics*, 97(1):11-22 (1986).

8. For a lucid discussion of this central contradiction of democracy that democratic rules may not have been arrived at by and may not be based on democratic support but only enable democracy to function, see Stephen Holmes, "Precommitment and the Paradox of Democracy," in *Constitutionalism and Democracy*, ed. John Elster and Rune Slagstad (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1988), pp. 195-240.

9. Albert O. Hirschman, *Shifting Involvements* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1981).

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may be rooted in human nature, but Hirschman wishes to emphasize the causal priority of economic structure and development as the engine behind the cycle.[10] Thus the advent of material abundance for a considerable share of the population has made the search for more abundance less meaningful and has generated serious consumer disappointments. These experiences are likely to lower the perception of the costs of participation in collective decision making and to increase the value of the democratic process as an end in itself. Public life, however, produces its own frustrations, such as the extreme efforts required to bring about even modest collective decisions, let alone leaving a personal imprint on the process and the outcome. Hirschman concludes, "In short, the trouble with political life is that it is either too absorbing or too tame."[11]

Hirschman's argument is empirically illustrated by Sidney Tarrow's incisive study of collective action in Italy that identifies a cyclical dynamic of mobilization in which the first sparks of collective protest feed on themselves, set a precedent that enables others to enter the social movement sector, expand the scope of contestation, and thus improve the opportunity structure for protest.[12] Analogous to a business cycle, however, this self-reinforcing dynamic eventually reaches a peak when slack resources have been spent, some demands and movement representatives are co-opted by the political elites, disappointments with the effectiveness of protest set in, and movements experience internal divisions, leading to a demobilization of most participants.[13] Tarrow empirically shows how Italian movements began to mobilize for reform from the early 1960s on and how more and more new causes crystallized around new repertoires of protest action that peaked in the late 1960s and then declined to the mid-1970s.

While Tarrow's penetrating and empirically meticulous study convincingly describes and analyzes the rise and decline of the Italian movement sector and its most important components over a span of more than a decade, it is questionable whether this wave of mobilization conforms to the image of a cycle that returns to its origin. For one thing, had Tarrow carried the analysis forward through the 1970s and 1980s, the empirical evidence would have revealed continued protest activities and oscillating levels of mobilization that may not abide by a cyclical pattern. Social movements appear to be caught up in the structural change of the Italian polity and have left a lasting impact on the nature of politics that plays a role even in periods when manifest movement protest is relatively dormant. I will pursue the theoretical underpinnings of this argument in

10. Ibid., p. 14.

11. Ibid., p. 119.

12. Sidney Tarrow, *Democracy and Disorder: Protest and Politics in Italy, 1965-1975* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1989).

13. Of course, cyclical models of political mobilization already underlie a cohort of natural-history studies on revolution, the major representatives of which are Crane Brinton, *The Anatomy of Revolution* (1938; reissued, New York: Harper & Row, 1965); Lyford Edwards, *The Natural History of Revolution* (1927; reissued, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972); George S. Pettee, *The Process of Revolution* (New York: Harper & Row, 1938).

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the next section. For now, I wish to focus on a different argument. Both Hirschman and Tarrow appear to suggest that the cycle has two phases that involve the hegemony of representative democracy (phase 1) and contestation by advocates of direct democracy (phase 2). Instead, I wish to argue that the two-phase model characterizes democratic decision-making cycles incompletely. There is a third mode of democratic decision making within such cycles that is rarely distinguished in the literature on democratic theory and social movements but that has considerable importance for the self-transformation of new social movements.

The evolution of Western democracies reveals considerable institutional variation over time and across space that is amenable to reconstruction in terms of democratic theory. The general idea that contemporary democracies reflect realist conceptions of democracy is too simplistic. Under the realist umbrella, at least two different modes of democratic decision making exist that can be roughly associated with Arend Lijphart's distinction between majoritarian and consensus democracies.[14] I will refer to them as the "liberal" and the "organizational" conceptions of democracy, both of which are distinct from the direct conception of democracy. In at least four respects, each of these three views of democracy conceives of political actors and institutions in different ways.[15] Moreover, each conception singles out different achievements of democracy. I will argue that citizens really want the achievements of all three modes of democratic choice and that what triggers their dissatisfaction with any existing institutional form is that each delivers only one achievement. This sets the stage for institutional cycles among three forms of democracy and three phases of disappointment and political transformation.

The three forms of the democratic process systematically vary in terms of who the competitors are, conception of citizenship, institutional design, and conception of interests.

1. The democratic competitors: For liberal democrats, the main competitors are candidates for and incumbents of elected office who are independent of special interests and relatively unconstrained by party activists. In contrast, the organized view of democracy sees mass parties with internally recruited leaders as the main competing entities. Mass parties treat leaders as spokespersons for the entire collective and maintain close ties to external mass organizations.[16] Finally, direct de-

14. Arend Lijphart, *Democracies* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1984).

15. Representatives for the liberal view of democracy are Dahl, *A Preface to Democratic Theory*; Riker, *Liberalism against Populism*; Joseph A. Schumpeter, *Capitalism, Socialism, and Democracy* (New York: Harper, 1950). Organized democracy is primarily supported in the socialist or the Catholic tradition and in recent writings is represented by Adam Przeworski, *Capitalism and Social Democracy* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1985). The direct democratic tradition is rooted in anarchosyndicalism and has been recently updated by Barber, *Strong Democracy*, and in a particularly inventive manner by John Burnheim, *Is Democracy Possible?* (Oxford: Polity Press, 1985).

16. In spite of allegations going as far back as Robert Michels, *Political Parties* (New York:

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mocracy refuses to draw a clear line between citizens, rank-and-file activists, and leaders in the democratic process. Relations to organized constituencies are only ad hoc, based on personal rather than formal ties and intermittent coalitions around particular issue positions supported by both parties and external groups.

2. Conception of citizenship: Liberal democrats see citizens as self-regarding individuals who experience political involvement as a burden to be delegated to a specialized group of professionals. Organizational democracy sees citizens as other-regarding and therefore contributing to mass parties; yet it also assumes that for most individuals, politics is a burden that is left to an accountable group of political specialists at the helm of the party. Finally, advocates of direct democracy consider citizens to be other-regarding and involved in politics as an opportunity for self-realization and self-transformation, not as a burden on one's time and energy.

3. Institutional design: The liberal democratic model presumes competitive majoritarian politics with plurality electoral systems, separation of powers, presidentialism, competition between party elites, and no formal role for special interest groups in the legislative process. The role of the electorate is to eliminate unpopular incumbents in periodic elections. For organizational democrats, the ideal type of democracy combines proportional representation of parties in the legislature, a functional division of government power, parliamentarism, bargaining and cooperation between party elites, and top-level ties to important interest groups.[17] For direct democrats, council democracy, popular referenda (initiatives, plebiscites), maybe representatives chosen by lottery from the entire citizenship, and the absence of special interest groups approximate the ideal set of institutions.

4. Conception of interests: Each set of democratic institutions is shaped by and promotes a different process of interest formation. For liberal democrats, citizens' preferences are formed in the prepolitical sphere, and the task of politicians is to aggregate such interests. For organizational democrats, parties shape the constituencies' preferences and interests through educational processes tied to the party organization as a potter shapes clay with his or her hands.[18] For advocates of direct democracy, preferences and interests are generated as a continuous process in the enactment of democratic choice. Actors discover their common objectives in a communicative process of political deliberation.

Free Press, 1962), a systematic divergence between party leaders and party activists, particularly in formally organized mass parties, cannot be systematically proved. See Herbert Kitschelt, "The Internal Politics of Parties: The Law of Curvilinearity Revisited," *Political Studies*, 37(3):400-421 (1989).

17. For the empirical characterization of liberal-majoritarian and organizational-consensual democracies, see Lijphart, *Democracies*, esp. pp. 214-16; Arend Lijphart and Marcus M. L. Crepaz, "Corporatism and Consensus Democracy in Eighteen Countries: Conceptual and Empirical Linkages," *British Journal of Political Science*, 21(2):235-46 (1991).

18. See, e.g., Przeworski, *Capitalism and Social Democracy*, chaps. 1-2, for his quasi-Leninist analysis of class formation as a political process that is consciously molded by political parties.

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In a well-known article on American political bureaucracy, Herbert Kaufman argued that citizens want an institutional design that delivers representativeness, competence, and executive leadership all at once. Yet closer inspection reveals that each administrative arrangement involves trade-offs between the three desirable objectives: decentralization of governance promotes representativeness but hurts competence and executive leadership; rule by a corps of expert professionals enhances competence but undercuts representativeness and executive leadership; centralization of administrative control, finally, boosts leadership, but reduces representativeness and competence.[19]

A similar set of trade-offs applies to the democratic institutions favored by liberal, organizational, and direct participatory democrats. Citizens expect democracy to provide (1) rationality in the sense of Pareto-optimal stable collective choices, (2) responsiveness to the demands of mobilized citizens, and (3) politicians' accountability to voters, even though the latter may not be directly mobilized. Liberal democracy delivers stable collective choice, although it also claims to be accountable. But citizens' ability to remove political leaders from office does not by itself establish a linkage of accountability. Accountability is the strength of organizational democracy, because mass parties provide a continuous mechanism to tie political leaders to a broad rank-and-file organization that mutually adjusts leaders' and followers' demands and expectations. Given that organizational democracy usually involves complex and shifting coalitional arrangements and policy compromises among government parties, democratic rationality, in the Arrovian sense of a unique collective welfare function, is not always served by the institutional arrangements.[20] Both liberal and organizational democrats attribute little weight to a democracy's capacity for responsiveness to mobilized citizens' demands. This is the emphasis of direct democracy. Yet direct democracy, lacking filters that constrain the range of choices, cannot guarantee collective rationality, nor is it particularly accountable to vast unmobilized constituencies.

Although this sketch overstates trade-offs by contrasting ideal types, it provides an instructive formulation of the trilemma of choosing democratic institutions. Existing democratic institutions trigger dissatisfaction that *may drive citizens in one of two different directions, depending on the concrete circumstances*. If liberal democracy prevails, there may be calls for organizational or direct par-

19. See Herbert Kaufman, "Emerging Conflict in the Doctrines of Public Administration," *American Political Science Review*, 50(4):1057-73 (1956).

20. This point was made in Anthony Downs, *An Economic Theory of Democracy* (New York: Harper & Row, 1957), chap. 9. He shows that two-party democracies permit party leaders to be rational and locate themselves near the median voter, whereas voters have no rational choice between different political positions—and hence cannot make leaders accountable to their preferences. In multiparty systems, voters can rationally choose parties close to their ideal position, but this rationality is undercut by the compromise policies that leaders must negotiate with other parties in order to join government coalitions.

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ticipatory democracy.[21] Conversely, organized democracies may be challenged by liberal conceptions or direct participatory visions.[22] Finally, direct democracy is besieged by calls for liberal reform or organizational structure.

These alternatives also influence the self-transformation of social movements, once disappointments set in with direct democracy. Activists and critical observers usually assume that contemporary social movements proceed from direct democracy to an organizational democracy with strong bureaucratic control. Michels's striking analysis of the self-transformation in socialist trade unions and parties at the beginning of the twentieth century has left its imprint on the mind of today's activists and scholars. Instead, I wish to argue that direct democracy in left-libertarian movements and parties will not be replaced by organizational democracy, but by liberal democratic institutions with personal representation inside small-framework parties that attract few members.[23] I am basing this hypothesis less on the conventional argument that the importance of the mass media and campaign technology in the electoral competition has rendered mass party organizations and organized democracy irrelevant.[24] More important are the entrenched individualism and voluntarism among movement and party activists that are detrimental to any effort to build centralized mass organizations, enforce formal rules, establish internal division of labor, and cultivate solidarity sentiments. As a consequence, left-libertarian political practices are more likely to become small framework associations in the hands of tiny coteries of individualist movement entrepreneurs and politicians with more or less political charisma.

The discourse on intraparty referendums in left-libertarian ecology parties, such as the German Greens and other European green parties, may demonstrate this logic of self-transformation.[25] Left-libertarians advocate popular referendums to overcome the constraints of partocracy. At the same time, however, they

21. Much of the debate about constitutional reform in Britain in the early 1990s is inspired by the apparent success of the European continent's more organizational democracies, while direct participatory demands are only an undercurrent. Conversely, in the United States it appears to me that the critique of the dominant liberal democratic conception usually calls for more grass-roots responsiveness and participatory decentralization rather than more organized democracy, a preference apparently confined to corporate technocrats and a considerable number of political scientists.

22. Especially partocracies such as Austria, Belgium, Italy, and most of the Scandinavian countries have witnessed left-libertarian challenges with a direct democratic inspiration, but also liberal democratic challenges from a New Right.

23. I have empirically substantiated this claim only for green parties, but not for social movements. See Herbert Kitschelt, *The Logics of Party Formation* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1989); idem, "New Social Movements and the Decline of Party Organization," in *Challenging the Political Order*, ed. Dalton and Kuechler, pp. 179-208.

24. The earliest representative of this position is Leon D. Epstein, *Political Parties in Western Democracies* (New York: Praeger, 1967). Such arguments overlook the multiple roles that mass party organizations play beyond the electoral process.

25. I am drawing on interview materials collected in the mid-1980s.

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refuse to employ intraorganizational plebiscites among all members to settle major policy or strategic disputes and to nominate leaders or candidates for elected office (primaries). Intraorganizational plebiscites and primaries would give a voice to those who do not regularly participate in political deliberation and thus do not benefit from the main advantage of direct democracy. Yet advocates of this view become intellectually insecure when confronted with the counterargument that democratic citizenship based on deliberation relapses into an elitist exclusionary form of political rule because it violates basic principles of democratic equality by disenfranchising all those who lack the resources—time, education, money—for effective participation.

Formal ballots and strict rules of intraorganizational representation of unmobilized rank-and-file members, however, would introduce mechanisms of organized democracy into left-libertarian parties vigorously rejected by the activists. As a consequence, left-libertarian movements and parties have made few efforts to overcome the perverse effects of direct democracy to be responsive to mobilized activists, but they deny accountability to broader citizens' constituencies. Where direct democracy has been displaced by other procedures, not organized democracy but liberal mechanisms of individualist representation and entrepreneurship have filled the void.

The argument that social movements are caught up in a cycle of democratic practices thus may yield quite different cycles depending on the ideological outlook and historical circumstances of social movements. Whereas working-class politics, inspired by a strong commitment to solidarity and compliance with the collective, moved from experiments with direct democracy to organized democracy, left-libertarian protest politics, driven by the quest for a decommodification and debureaucratization of society, are more likely to adopt patterns of liberal democratic politics. As a consequence, contemporary social movements in continental European democracies are not caught up in a cycle that leads back to the full affirmation of organized democracy. Rather, they infuse elements of a liberal-individualist and competitive tradition of democracy into democracies that have been dominated by mechanisms of inter-elite bargaining and consensus building through large encompassing organizations of interest intermediation.

THE STRUCTURAL DIFFERENTIATION OF DEMOCRATIC PRACTICES AND SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

My critique of cyclical models of democratic institutionalization and social movements has challenged the proposition that, at the end of each cycle, the status quo ante will be reaffirmed. Beyond this defensive, negative argument, I would now like to take the offensive and suggest that some residues of direct democratic practices persist in the self-transformation of contemporary social movements, even though in a muted and constrained way. My hypothesis is based on the theory that issues of collective decision making are characterized by qualitative differences.

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Different democratic choice procedures are better or worse equipped to handle certain classes of collective choice problems.

The dominant actors in three democratic decision modes have already been introduced: individual legislators (liberal democracy); mass parties (organized democracy); individual citizens and social movements (direct democracy). I will now add a fourth mode of decision making—corporatist interest intermediation—whose dominant actors are large encompassing interest groups that hammer out policy compromises in top-level bargaining with the assistance of state authority.[26] The key question, then, is, Why are there parties, individual legislators, interest groups, and social movements all at once and not one single type of political actor? Further, why are there different modes of interest articulation, aggregation, and decision making in democracies?

The cyclical view of social movements essentially claims that the differentiation of political actors and decision modes is transitory and that, in equilibrium, only one mode will persist. An alternative theory that insists on the structural differentiation of the modern polity affirms the coexistence of different decision modes and types of political actors, including social movements. It is based on the idea that each decision mode has particular comparative advantages for handling a class of decision problems.

Collective decision problems may be distinguished with respect to their substantive and their temporal complexity. In substantive respects, political issues may present discrete or interdependent problems of choice. Discrete problems can be resolved without taking into account the issue's ramifications for other policy choices, whereas interdependent issues spill over onto a wide range of other issues. In temporal respects, political issues may require permanent attention by democratic decision makers and a continuous demand for collective decisions, or they may require intermittent attention and decisions. Where setting policy objectives and implementation are closely intertwined, issues require permanent democratic monitoring. Intermittent problems, in contrast, involve point decisions that define the policy, which then is either self-enforcing or easily monitored in the implementation process. Overall, then, there are four ideal typical decision problems: intermittent and interdependent; intermittent and discrete; permanent and interdependent; and permanent and discrete.

Liberal democratic institutions giving individual legislators a prominent role are likely to deal best with intermittent-interdependent issues and are likely to define or redefine problems of collective decision making as intermittent-interdependent. Individual legislators have a short time horizon and are thus more capable of dealing with intermittent deci-

26. There is no democratic theory that corresponds to corporatist decision making because this type of decision making does not share the basic premise of democracy that all citizens should have equal weight in the decision process. On the political theory of corporatism, see Peter J. Williamson, *Varieties of Corporatism: A Conceptual Discussion* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1986).

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sion matters, yet they are predisposed to examining issue interdependence. Because voter choices are affected by a multitude of issue positions signaled by a legislator, the latter must monitor issue interdependence in order to maintain his or her chances for reelection. Issues that lend themselves to logrolling on a case-by-case basis, such as pork barrel politics over budgets and projects, are most easily handled in settings with dominant legislators. Liberal representation can cope with substantive complexity (interdependence) but not with temporal complexity (permanence of decision making).

Substantively and temporally complex problems are handled better by integrated political parties in parliamentary democracies that instill a long time horizon in their legislative representatives and leadership; these circumstances allow parties to make more robust commitments to long-term policies while being less deterred by short-term opportunistic considerations of this or that politician's popularity.[27] In fact, the rationality of strong parties is to develop a reputation for a general political outlook that allows rational voters to commit themselves to the party in the anticipation that it will continue to propagate the implementation of its main tenets. This same rationality makes it difficult for large mass parties to respond quickly to temporally intermittent or substantively highly discrete policy issues.

In contrast to mass parties, interest groups focus on a narrower range of policy issues and dedicate a greater amount of their organizational resources to limited causes. This greater asset specificity of interest groups permits them to mobilize contributors and members in a more targeted way than parties can. This advantage, however, also prevents them from entering electoral politics, in which they would be compelled to take into account the interdependence of their most cherished causes with other policy issues. The corporatist participation of interest groups in public policymaking thus works only in functionally specific policy areas and presupposes relatively encompassing interest groups. Mass parties do well to cultivate their ties to interest groups, yet also to keep their distance from them in order to maintain their reputation for addressing the complex interdependence of policy issues.

Interest groups, like parties, are capable of engaging in issues that require a steady stream of policy decisions and monitoring of implementation. Both have few incentives to invest scarce political resources into intermittent and functionally specific issues that mobilize constituencies only briefly. It is with this type of decision problem that social movements have a clear competitive advantage over interest groups and parties. The asset specificity of social

27. It is no accident, therefore, that organized democracies have typically invested more in collective goods such as infrastructure and comprehensive social welfare institutions than liberal-competitive democracies, which have tended to provide more rents for special interests. My argument resembles Olson's claim that "encompassing" groups have a greater capacity to pursue collective goals than narrow interest groups do. See Mancur Olson, *The Rise and Decline of Nations* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1982), pp. 47-53.

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movements concerns both the temporal and the substantive dimension. The character of the decision problem also explains why movements often prefer popular referenda to parliamentary decisions or bargaining among parties and interest groups as the appropriate democratic mechanism of authoritative decision making. The popular referendum is uniquely geared to intermittent and functionally independent point decisions.[28]

Social movements thrive on intermittent and discrete decision problems for a number of reasons. It is comparatively costless to mobilize large numbers of individuals around clearly defined, discrete, and visible issues, particularly if these decisions (1) involve a step good in which the choice is between providing all or none of the good, and (2) organize against a collective ill, giving the movement a protective mission, rather than demand a new collective good that engages the group in a proselytizing mission.[29] Fights against particular instances of discrimination, abuse, pollution, or repression illustrate this dynamic particularly sharply. Their concern for discrete and intermittent issues also means that it is not worthwhile for social movements to invest in lasting organizational assets, such as charters, office space, and permanent staff. This reduces pressures on movement entrepreneurs to develop a complicated machinery of decision making despised by many grass-roots activists. Avoiding organization investments maintains the homogeneity of participants' preferences and lowers the burdens of raising finances, a need that usually forces an organization to attract not just purposively motivated activists but also contributors who primarily respond to marginal selective incentives—material, social—and thus burden the movement with dead weight. Overall, then, discrete intermittent decision problems tend to facilitate a more communicative, fluid, deliberative internal decision process in movements in which the main rewards of membership are intrinsic to the process of mobilization itself.

In light of these considerations, the organizational logic and internal differentiation of contemporary social movements such as those focused on ecology or feminism become intelligible. Within each issue domain, the nature of the decision problem interacts with the movement's organizational form. In environmental movements, there is a clear division between movements fighting about particular projects and facilities—nuclear installations, industrial plants, toxic waste disposal, and so on—and efforts to develop and legislate long-term environmental policies that take into account the temporal and substantive complexity of the subject matter. While project-oriented environmentalists stay close to the direct democratic movement

28. Benevolent evaluations of the usefulness of popular referenda therefore defend this decision mode against a general critique by advocates of representative procedures, but they admit that the appropriateness of this approach varies across decision arenas. See Thomas E. Cronin, *Direct Democracy: The Politics of Initiative, Referendum, and Recall* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989), esp. chap. 8.

29. See Russell Hardin, *Collective Action* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1982), pp. 55-66.

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structures, long-term ecological policymaking is usually developed by often highly professionalized ecological interest groups, research institutions, and even parties.[30]

In the feminist sector, a similar structural differentiation can be recognized. On the one hand, there are movements supporting or opposing particular point decisions—abortion rights, restriction of pornography, equal rights amendments, and so on—that clearly favor fluid direct democratic practices. The same applies to women's groups whose intrinsic goals are oriented more toward cultural change than toward pure policy decisions. Such groups tend to develop a communal infrastructure of bookshops, coffeehouses, media projects, child care initiatives, or shelters for battered women that only intermittently engages in political activity. On the other hand, feminist groups concerned with women's employment opportunities and other issues that require constant involvement in policy formulation and monitoring of implementation have developed formal interest group structures or have established themselves inside parties and interest groups. A similar division of labor among different organizational forms can probably be found in other movements, such as those of ethnic and cultural minorities.

A comparison of the different expressions of environmental and feminist concerns is likely to show that environmental groups have developed a greater propensity to accept formal interest groups than have women's movements. The ecological issue belongs to a politics of space in which questions of self-organization, deliberation, consensus, and preference change through consciousness-raising are held important but not essential to the attainment of the movements' objectives. In contrast, for movements engaging in the politics of social identity, such as most women's groups, means and ends, processes of mobilization and objective, cannot be clearly differentiated. To a large extent, the objective of the movements' practices is embodied in the process itself. In such groups, not only the orientation toward point decisions but the interdependence between process and goals inhibit instrumental organization in ways instituted by parties and interest groups. Maybe for this reason, there are many ecology parties, yet hardly a single successful women's party.[31]

The importance of cultural practices and the orientation of contemporary social movements toward intermittent and discrete policy issues suggests that, in empirical investigations, it is insufficient to examine movements' overt protest activities. Instead, it is vital to explore the persistence of "latent movements" embodied in interpersonal networks and nodes of communications that former activists maintain throughout periods with relatively few manifest protest engagements.[32] When new issues

30. An interesting hybrid that may therefore be unstable is Greenpeace. This group has made the effort to build a lasting organization around primarily discrete and intermittent activities and causes.

31. The Icelandic women's party is the exception.

32. See Alberto Melucci, *Nomads of the Present: Social Movements and Individual*

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arise, participants can call upon such networks to mobilize for protest action. Latent social movement networks maintain a cultural and political capacity to monitor societal developments. In this vein, they constitute a threat potential that parties and interest groups have begun to reckon with. For example, this threat potential also surfaced in opinion polls in the late 1980s, revealing that the popular predisposition to participate in social movements had increased even at times when actual manifest protests had subsided.[33]

In advanced capitalist democracies, citizens' personal resources to engage in direct democratic practices have increased. At the same time, the scope and depth of policy issues that give rise to discrete point decisions vulnerable to challenge by social movements appear to have increased. Furthermore, if the latent readiness of fluid social networks to mobilize protest activities is taken into account, in addition to citizens' manifest protest behavior, it is difficult to get around the conclusion that in the 1980s and 1990s advanced industrial democracies exhibit qualitatively new patterns of democratic politics and an increasing differentiation of the avenues of political involvement.

This new configuration, however, indicates less a polarization of different modes of participation and democratic decision making than the opportunity for a new complementarity. As Olsen argued in his study of Norwegian democracy in the early 1980s, advanced democracies face the problem not of replacing complex political and economic institutions with social movements but of finding ways to accommodate spontaneity, individuality, entrepreneurship, and responsiveness in a bureaucratic and commodified society.[34] Both scholars of comparative politics and of political theory therefore are well advised to go beyond conventional dichotomies and study the complex interaction of and the contingent role played by specific modes of democratic participation and decision making in different policy arenas.[35]

CONCLUSION

As Lijphart has shown, Western democracies embody different conceptions of democracy. Some come closer to a liberal-democratic competitive and majoritarian model of democracy, others to that of an organ-

Needs in Contemporary Society (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1989), esp. pp. 70-75.

33. See the analysis of West German survey data in Dieter Fuchs, "The Normalization of the Unconventional: New Forms of Political Action and New Social Movements," in *Political Participation and Democracy in Poland and West Germany*, ed. Gerd Meyer and Franciszek Ryszka (Warsaw: Wydawca, 1991), pp. 148-69.

34. Johan P. Olsen, *Organized Democracy: Political Institutions in a Welfare State: The Case of Norway* (Bergen: Universitetsforlaget, 1983), esp. pp. 30-31.

35. Mark Warren has taken a first step in this direction in democratic theory by arguing that the chances of direct democratic and deliberative modes of decision making are affected by the nature of the goods discussed in politics. His typology of collective goods, however, is much more complex than my own modest proposal. See Mark Warren, "Democratic Theory and Self-Transformation," *American Political Science Review*, 86(1):8-23 (1992). Another effort to grasp the structural differentiation of modern democracy has been made by Held, *Models of Democracy*, chap. 9.

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ized and more consensual democracy. Interestingly, the only variable in Lijphart's study that reflects a trace of direct participatory democracy, the frequency of referendums in a country, is unrelated to liberal or organized features of democratic institutions.[36] This suggests that there are indeed three different and independent modes of democratic governance that comparative political scientists and political theorists should distinguish as well.

In this article, I have argued that contemporary social movements represent an effort to redress the balance between the three modes of democracy in favor of direct participatory methods. Yet the thrust of my argument has also been directed against overly enthusiastic expectations that direct democracy could supplant liberal and organized modes of democratic decision making.[37] An infusion of direct democratic elements results from a differentiation of political issues and decision modes, not from a wholesale displacement of existing institutions. Furthermore, Hirschman's and Tarrow's insight into the wavelike distribution of social movements should be taken seriously. Even within a system of democratic differentiation, the relative impact of social movements and participatory politics will vary over time. Nevertheless, all this should not distract from the qualitative changes in the practice and opportunities for democratic participation evidenced by advanced capitalist democracies since the advent of collective protest mobilization in the 1960s.

36. See Lijphart, *Democracies*, p. 214.

37. Barber's *Strong Democracy* represents one of the most recent efforts to revive an all-but-unrestrained call for direct democracy.

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